involved in temple affairs for fear of giving religious offence. However, they then accepted that as the new ruling power they had a duty to provide some level of financial aid to make up for the shortfall brought about by the loss of revenue from previous royal patrons. In 1814 John Wallace, Collector of Tanjore, reported that 993 temples in his Collectorate were each receiving thirty-seven thousand gold pagodas from the Madras Presidency Government. But at the same time, Wallace was receiving complaints from pilgrims about ‘undue exactions’ by the temple authorities and the misuse of endowments. He was also having to mediate in temple disputes, chiefly involving quarrels over access between Vatakalais and Tenkalais, the northern and southern branches respectively of Tamil Vaishnavism.

Wallace recommended that the management of temple finances and some temple affairs should be brought under the control of a government-appointed Superintendent. As a result, the Madras Government became embroiled in temple management to a ridiculous degree. In 1834 we find Robert Nelson, Assistant Collector of Tanjore, complaining that as part of his official duties he was expected to provide all the main temples with ‘coolies’ to draw their *rathas* – the great chariots that carry *murtis* of the temple deities in procession during the major festivals. Almost unbelievably, Tanjore’s most important festival alone required no fewer than thirty thousand such coolies, and in that particular year the two principal festivals had coincided with a harvest season affected by heavy rains so that much of the grain had been lost.[4] The outcome was that in 1841 the EICo’s Board of Directors in London ordered all three Presidency governments to withdraw from ‘interference in the management of all Native religious institutions’.

However, continued complaints of temple mismanagement and caste discrimination finally led the Madras Presidency Government to take the view that